The ‘persons’ who would remain in India for the achievement of the said ‘benevolent’ designs were Christian missionaries, and this becomes evident not only from the literature[17] but also from other provisions of the Act. Sections 49–54 of the Act provided an elaborate scheme for the creation of a church establishment in the British Territories in India with the appointment of one bishop and three archdeacons for Calcutta, Madras and Bombay. Further, under Section 43, a sum of not less than a lakh of rupees would be set apart annually ‘for the revival and improvement of literature, and the encouragement of the learned natives of India, and *for the introduction and promotion of a knowledge of the sciences among the inhabitants of the British Territories in India*’ [emphasis added], which underscores the colonial belief that the sciences have European origins. Based on the provisions of the 1813 Act, it could be reasonably inferred that the intent of the Company as expressed in 1614 and 1659 to spread Christianity among the people of Bharat, had formally crystallised into the establishment of a Christian ecosystem in Bharat under the mandate of the Crown and the British Parliament.

The evangelical intent behind these provisions shines through the debates that took place in the British Parliament in relation to the 1813 Act, prior to its promulgation. In fact, according to the literature, the unequivocal provision of State support for the establishment and spread of Christianity in Bharat, as reflected in the 1813 Act, was a result of the persistent efforts of missionary groups for several years.[18] The conviction with which the case for Christianity in Bharat was pitched is evident from the fact that proponents of missionary work genuinely believed that the improvement of the condition of the people of Bharat was intimately bound to one essential prerequisite—conversion to Christianity. The resistance of the Company to increased missionary activity in Bharat until the 1813 Act did not spring from the well of religious neutrality or ‘secularism’ as some would like to believe, but was merely the product of mercantile pragmatism. There is no denying that the issue had multiple layers with several parties having divergent views and interests. That said, not a single one of the different strains of these views was remotely interested in non-interference with native faith systems out of respect for their beliefs and practices.

To add to this mix, the tussle between the Church of England, the official denomination of England, and Protestant Dissenters turned Bharat into yet another battleground for the conflict between Christian denominations.[19]